

CHAPTER 9

Style, Strategy, and Skill in Reading

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Reading is typical of a variety of complex cognitive performances which involve a large number of discrete but interdependent mental processes. The processes which are brought to bear in any particular instance of reading are a function of the task difficulty, the reader's general and specific skills, and the reader's purpose in performing the particular task. Each of these factors is in turn subject to extensive (and so far interminable) subdivision and elaboration. Thus while a comprehensive theory of reading can be outlined, it is not yet possible to specify sufficient detail to prescriptively guide instruction or to understand the entire reading behavior of individual subjects. This chapter briefly examines the outline of what appears to be a consensus theory of reading but then concentrates upon a particular class of reading processes, those loosely within the domain of styles and strategies. A feature of this analysis, and an important conclusion from it, is that the effects of this domain must be understood in conjunction with the effects of a second domain, which can equally loosely be termed *skills*.

This chapter is composed of four sections. In the remainder of this first section, a framework is described for understanding the two domains mentioned above, and some research and measurement problems discussed. Section two outlines a general theory of reading, underlining its hierarchical and interactive aspects. The third section selects potential

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areas of strategic involvement and reviews some evidence regarding each area. The final section elaborates implications for instructional applications and questions for future research.

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

TWO DOMAINS OF COGNITIVE PROCESSES

Recent psychological theory and research has tended to divide cognitive processes into two domains which can loosely be termed those of strategies and skills. The basic distinction between these is not hard to grasp at first, but terminological confusion obscures much work in the area, and detailed examination of any instance of either class seems to lead unavoidably to recognition that the other is also involved. Neither of these forms of confusion eliminates the heuristic value of the basic distinction, but they do recommend caution.

The distinction between strategies and skills is based on the argument that *skills* are existing cognitive routines for performing specified tasks, and *strategies* are the means of selecting, combining, or redesigning those cognitive routines. Skills range from *knowledge skills*, the accessing by stimulus patterns of stored representations and associations (e.g., knowing that "7" says "seven") to *action skills*, the transforming of input information to obtain desired results (e.g., adding numbers). Skills can also be either specific (knowing that $2 + 2$ equals 4) or general (knowing how to add numbers). Skills are fundamentally related to *abilities*, to the extent that the latter sets some sort of upper limit to the development of the former. In this sense abilities represent some preexisting level of "potential" (the product of constitutional and experiential factors), which limits the level which skills can attain or the speed with which those levels can be attained (see Figure 1).

Strategies, on the other hand, involve choice or decision making. The strategy domain consists of tactics, strategies, and styles (see Figure 1). A *tactic* is the decision to employ a certain skill (e.g., deciding to add two numbers). A *strategy* is a combination of tactics, or a choice among

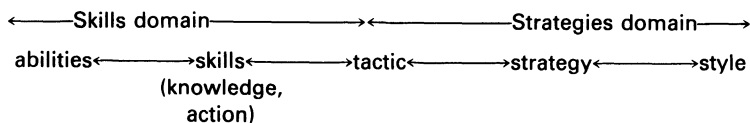


Figure 1. Terminology within skills and strategies domains.